



Protocol – Systematic Review

A systematic review of the barriers and facilitators to the use of evidence experienced by philanthropists when determining what to fund.

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Citation

Caroline Greenhalgh & Paul Montgomery. A systematic review of the barriers to and facilitators of the use of evidence utilised by philanthropists when determining which charities, including health charities or programmes to fund.

Review Question

What barriers to and facilitators of the use of evidence do philanthropists experience when deciding which charities, including health charities and/or programmes to fund?

Rationale

A drive to more evidence-based philanthropy first emerged in the UK in the late nineteenth century, as social reformers such as Charles Booth and Beatrice Webb employed social research methods in an effort to address social problems. In 1997, the then incoming Labour government made a commitment to evidence based policy-making (EBPM) *'in which evidence of 'What works and how?' would underpin policy-making decisions'* in the belief that this would lead to better outcomes, with less effective government programmes being replaced with *'new more effective, less harmful approaches.'* (Rutter 2013 cited in Greenhalgh, 2017 p.7).

Today there is increasing recognition amongst philanthropists, charity leaders and policy makers, that in order to be effective, the process of giving resources needs to be grounded in evidence. However, it is often suggested that there is insufficient evidence upon which philanthropists can rely, in part because *'good quality data on successful interventions is still not widely published'* (Kassatly, 2018 p.1).

This paper aims to identify limiting and promoting factors regarding the use of evidence by philanthropists and to evaluate existing research on this issue. The meaning of philanthropy is contested, however, for the purposes of this study, the following construct of philanthropy will be utilised: in which philanthropy signifies giving by wealthy individuals and foundations with the intent of addressing social problems (Daly, 2012, Eberhardt and Madden, 2017).

Policy makers seeking to employ an evidence-based approaches to policy making, may be reluctant to take up and utilise evidence, unless it is graded for quality. In an effort to address this, the authors are



utilising the GRADE-CERqual (Grading of Recommendations Assessment, Development, and Evaluation - Confidence in the Evidence from Reviews of Qualitative research) approach (Lewin S, 2018) as this will permit us to ascertain the level of confidence that we can have in our findings.

Searches

The search strategy will be constructed to ensure that it comprehensively reviews all the current literature on studies which examine factors which serve to either act as barriers to or facilitators of the use of evidence by philanthropists.

Due to a *'lack of rigorous, independent research to provide an authoritative basis for our understanding of philanthropic activity'* (Centre for Philanthropy, 2018) it is anticipated that it will be a challenge to uncover much literature relating to the use of evidence by philanthropists. The authors will therefore broaden their search to include grey literature derived from philanthropic based websites, philanthropy think-tanks and experts in the field.

The researchers initially identified a small body of research examining this topic through Google Scholar and subsequent hand-searching of the bibliographies of those articles. The online databases (listed below) will be searched using a search string which will be developed following consultations with an information systems expert: ABI/INFORM Global, ASSIA, CDS, Campbell Library, DARE, Embase, IBSS, Medline, Scopus, Social Care Online, SocSci Abstracts, PAIS and OpenGrey (anticipated search dates: January 2019 – March 2019).

Inclusion Criteria

The main objective of this review is to identify, evaluate and synthesize appropriate, rigorous research examining factors which serve to act as barriers to or facilitators of the use of evidence by philanthropists. To be eligible for inclusion, studies must have been published in English and be primary research or systematic reviews investigating the perceptions and/or experiences of philanthropists relating to their use of evidence. All study designs will be eligible for inclusion provided they examine factors affecting the use of evidence by philanthropists however, such factors need not be the primary focus of those studies. Studies investigating the perceptions of professionals (such as charity CEO's; philanthropic advisors and philanthropic consultants) as to how evidence is used by philanthropists will also be eligible for inclusion. Articles will initially be screened at the title, publication date and abstract level by CG using Rayyan and Endnote by both authors.

Participants/Population

The population of interest is that of high net worth individual donors (HNWDs) namely, individuals with liquid assets of more than US\$1 million (Investopedia, 2018) - who make significant donations (sometimes referred to as 'major gifts') to fund charities or programmes. This population is of interest because in recent years they have contributed to a significant growth in giving, indeed, *'major philanthropy has been on the rise since the financial crisis, with 2016 seeing the highest amount given*



since the report began a decade ago. (Breeze, 2017). In light of the increasingly competitive funding environment, such a rise in donations by HNWDs is therefore both significant and of particular interest to charities. Consequently, the way in which the wealthy practice philanthropy and how they utilise evidence in their decision making is a key question which needs to be explored so that the findings of such research can be disseminated to charities to better enable them to develop and manage their relationships with such donors in order to access their financial support.

There is no single definition of a 'major gift' which is context dependent and varies across charities and programmes. *'Breeze and Lloyd found that 90% of their major donor respondents cited £10,000 or above as a major gift indicating serious interest from the donor'* (Eberhardt and Madden, 2017 p.4), For the purposes of this study the authors have drawn upon Breeze and Lloyd's findings and fixed upon a minimum of US£10,000 per annum.

Primary outcome(s)

Factors operating as barriers or facilitators to the use of evidence by philanthropists.

The meaning of 'evidence' is contested, *'particularly in light of the differing types and weight of evidence in the social sciences'* (Wells 2007 cited in Greenhalgh, 2017). Indeed, as Cairney points out: *'the type of evidence that will prove the most useful in determining the best policy to address a particular social problem, will to an extent, be determined by the nature of the question being asked.'* (Cairney 2016 cited in Greenhalgh, 2017)

Anticipated findings relating to barriers include: insufficient time and resources to uncover relevant information; insufficient robust evidence; and a lack of trust in the sources of the information. Expected facilitators of the use of evidence include: peer recommendations; conferences and philanthropy clubs or intermediaries.

Data extraction (selection and coding)

All study data will be independently extracted by CG and checked by PM as follows:

- Publication year and author
- Rationale
- Methods and design
- Population (type of philanthropist/donor)
- Charity sector and purpose
- Results (i.e. barriers and facilitators to the use of evidence by philanthropists)
- Discussion (opportunities for further study)

Studies will be coded to extract data on methods, topic, focus and results.



Risk of Bias and Quality Assessment

It is not the intention of this study to ascertain effect sizes but instead our intention is to '*describe a body of literature*' (Oliver et al., 2014 p.2).

All included studies will be assessed for quality by utilising adapted tools including the Joanna Briggs Institute (Joanna Briggs Institute, 2017) technique for qualitative studies and the AXIS checklist for survey studies (BMJ, 2016).

Strategy for data synthesis

Thematic analysis (Oliver et al., 2014) will be utilised to integrate the data, in which the main findings and theories will be extrapolated and then ordered as either barriers or facilitators to form a '*narrative synthesis*' (Oliver et al., 2014). Factors identified as being either barriers or facilitators (regarding the use of evidence by philanthropists) will be listed and vote-counting techniques will be employed (subject to study size and methodological rigour). Ideally, the researchers would not utilise vote-counting techniques as they do not typically consider study methods or study quality and as such can '*introduce serious bias into a review*' (Petticrew and Roberts, 2006 p.6). However, by employing thematic analysis to order the individual factors any variations in factors '*revolving around the same underlying problem*' (Bach-Mortensen and Montgomery, 2018 p.2) can be accounted for.

Tables will be utilised to capture all the data extrapolated from the studies captured by the review, including: a Summary of Qualitative Findings Table comprising: study methodology, study participants and findings. A further table will illustrate the findings of the critical appraisal undertaken for each study.

Initially qualitative data will be synthesized using NVivo software; should the review include quantitative studies then subsequently both qualitative and quantitative syntheses will be combined (Petticrew and Roberts, 2006).

Significant findings will be extrapolated and summarised by theme and as such form a narrative synthesis (Oliver et al., 2014). The construction of the themes will be an inductive process (Bach-Mortensen et al., 2018) however, it is anticipated that thematic sub-headings could include:

- Types of evidence available for use;
- Barriers to the use of evidence;
- Facilitators to the use of evidence;
- Perceptions of philanthropists;
- Perceptions of charity and philanthropy professionals.
- Cause/charity sector

Contact details for further information

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Conflicts of interest

There are no reported conflicts of interest.

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Ongoing

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APPENDIX A

CERQual Evidence Profile of Individual Studies

Study Title	Summary of Review Finding	Methodological Limitations	Coherence	Adequacy	Relevance	CERQual assessment of confidence in the evidence	Explanation of CERQual assessment

CERQual Summary of Qualitative Findings Table

Objective: To identify, appraise and synthesise qualitative research evidence on the barriers and facilitators to the use of evidence by philanthropists when deciding what to fund.

Perspective: Experiences and attitudes of philanthropists about evidence in any country.

Summary of Review Finding	Studies contributing to the review finding	CERQual assessment of confidence in the evidence	Explanation of CERQual assessment